CASE STUDY

parakh

Practise investing with fake money, and see honestly what works.

An educational stock platform for beginner Indian investors, in sync with the real market.

Try the app: parakh-bi78.vercel.app | Code on GitHub

Vanshaj Verma · 2026

परख: to test true worth, the way a jeweller tests gold on a touchstone

THE PROBLEM

Beginners get stock tips with no receipts.

No track record

Nobody shows how often they've been right before.

No confidence

Every tip arrives as a "sure shot".

No reasoning

Nothing to learn from, and nothing to check.

Parakh's bet: show the receipts, starting with its own.

THE ORIGINAL BET

Will this stock beat the NIFTY 50 over the next 5 trading days?

10 years

of daily prices, 2016 to today

50 stocks

the whole NIFTY 50, plus an index ETF

18:00 IST

calls published daily, before the next open

Why the index? A beginner's honest alternative to picking a stock is an index fund, so every call is judged against one.

THE HONEST TEST

Rules first, then a holdout nobody had looked at.

Holdout 2025–26	Calls that were right	Rank IC (t)
A one-line rule (ships)	48.7% of 2,188	0.017 (0.87)
LightGBM, 15 features	52.5% of 2,147	0.040 (1.46)
Coin flip	50%	0

Neither was reliably better than a coin flip.

THE TURNING POINT

If even the model can’t beat a coin flip, the lesson is the product.

So Parakh became a place to practise with fake money, where every result is judged against simply holding an index fund.

IN SYNC WITH THE REAL MARKET

Every weekday: a new close, new calls.

18:00 IST

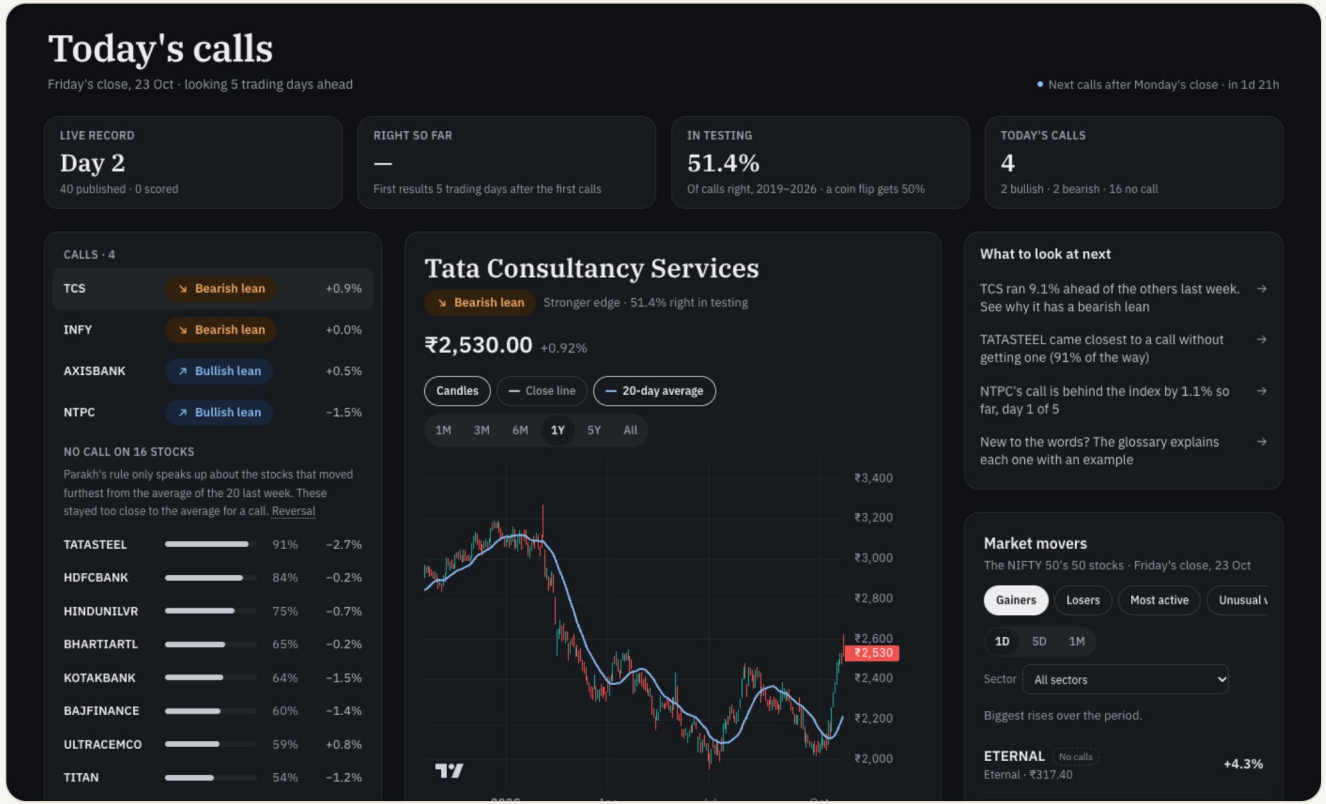
Fresh prices after the NSE close

Score, then publish

Matured calls scored; the next ones stored before the open

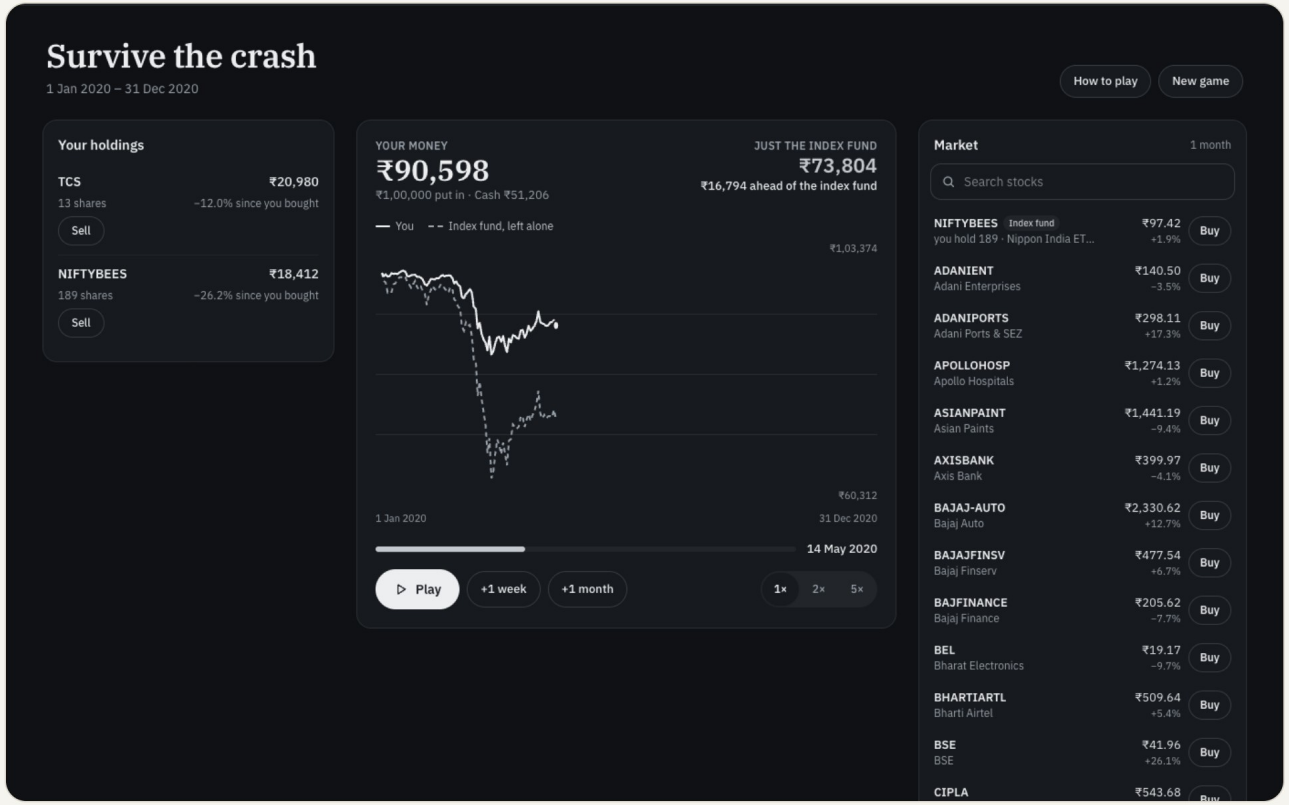
Receipts on every call

Track record, holdout, and why a stock got no call



THE TIME MACHINE

Replay real markets with fake money.



Pick a period

The 2020 crash, the 2021 rally, flat months, a decade of SIP, or a mystery window

Trade like it’s real

Next-morning fills, whole shares, real charges itemised

Get interrupted

At sharp moves: hold, sell or buy more?

THE REPORT CARD

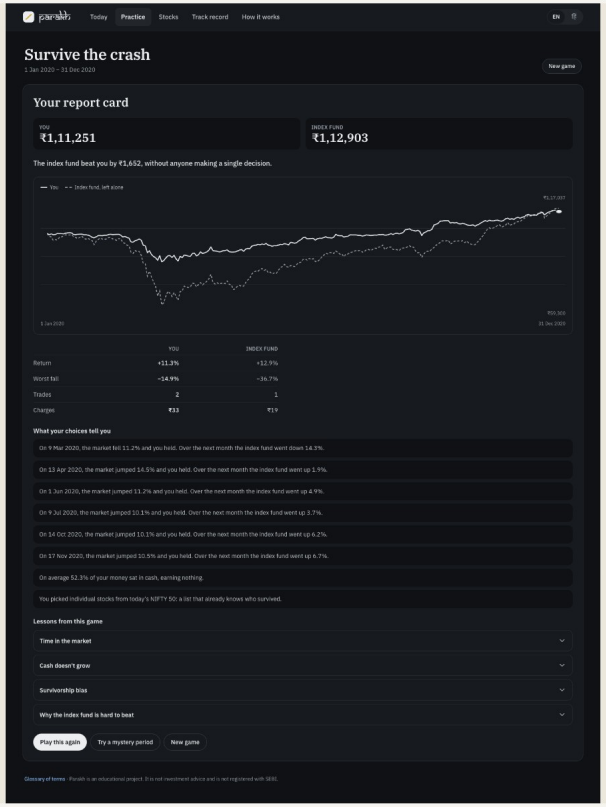
One choice, ₹17,744 apart.

₹1,12,903

₹1 lakh left in the index fund through 2020, despite a 37% fall

₹95,159

The same money, sold in panic on 23 March and bought back in June



WHAT A PLAYTEST CHANGED

The first player left 98.6% of the money in cash.

The rules were fine. The first minute wasn't.

- A picture strip and a spotlight tour, shown not told
- A one-tap "Buy the index fund" to start
- A guide strip that never moves the Play button
- English and Hindi, with a 27-term glossary



TRUST OVER FEATURES

Four calls that each cost something.

Dropped a label

A SQL check showed “stronger edge” did worse than “slight edge”.

Switched off news

Built, then paused: the feed’s terms don’t allow public display.

No early verdicts

Calls in progress say “Not a result yet”, never “off track”.

Caveats on screen

Survivorship bias and adjusted prices are disclosed in the app.

WHAT I LEARNT

Three things I’d do earlier next time.

01 Run the dumbest baseline first

A one-line rule matched weeks of feature engineering.

02 Fix the test before the first experiment

Early results looked better than they were while the metric kept moving.

03 Put a real beginner in front of it sooner

One session exposed what weeks of building hadn’t.

TRY IT

parakh

Play: parakh-bi78.vercel.app

Code: github.com/vanshajvr/parakh

The README, a SQL analysis of the record, and 46 decisions written down with their alternatives.

A personal, non-commercial portfolio project. Not investment advice.